COMP3122 Information Systems Development

Group #8

Final Project Report

STEM Learning Platform with GenAI

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This report documents the current implemented state of the repository, including the web application, Python backend, Supabase schema and Edge Functions, testing strategy, deployment topology, and role-based user workflows.

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1 Executive Summary

This project delivers a production-oriented STEM learning platform that integrates Generative AI into classroom workflows rather than treating AI as a detached chatbot. Its main idea is to let instructors upload teaching materials, convert those materials into a structured *Course Blueprint*, and use that blueprint as the source of truth for downstream student learning activities such as grounded chat, quizzes, flashcards, assignment review, and class-level insights.

The implemented system is split into three cooperating runtime surfaces:

- a **Next.js 16** web application for role-aware user experience, route handling, and server actions;
- a **Python FastAPI** backend for AI orchestration, class workflows, analytics, and chat memory management; and
- a **Supabase** project for authentication, PostgreSQL persistence, row-level security, storage, queue-backed material processing, and guest sandbox lifecycle support.

From a product perspective, the platform supports:

- **instructors** who create classes, upload materials, generate and publish blueprints, create assignments, review submissions, and inspect analytics;
- **students** who join classes with join codes, use the published blueprint, complete assignments, and learn through grounded AI chat; and
- **guest users** who can explore the product through a realistic sandboxed demo flow backed by Supabase Anonymous Auth and sandbox-cloned data.

The repository also demonstrates a meaningful software engineering process. The current snapshot contains 403 commits, 92 merge commits, 23 active database migrations, 61 web test files, 20 backend test files, 10 Playwright end-to-end specifications, and a documented deployment topology across web, backend, and Supabase services. The live deployed product is available at `ai-stem-learning-platform-group-8.vercel.app`. The result is not a toy prototype, but a coordinated educational platform with clear subsystem boundaries and operational considerations.

2 Project Background and Motivation

2.1 Course and problem context

The course brief frames the project in the broader language of *Education 4.0*, personalized learning, and AI-supported teaching. That framing is useful, but the repository shows that the real product challenge is more concrete: classroom AI must do more than answer questions. Teachers need a system that can absorb their materials, structure them into trustworthy course knowledge, turn that knowledge into student-facing activities, and still leave the teacher in editorial control.

In practice, the pain points are operational as much as pedagogical. A teacher does not only need “an AI”; they need help with lesson preparation, activity creation, assignment delivery,

review, and follow-up instruction. Students, in turn, do not benefit much from a generic chatbot that has no understanding of what their class is actually studying. They need a guided workspace grounded in the same materials, objectives, and assignments that the teacher is using.

This project responds to that problem by treating the class itself as the unit of AI orchestration. Uploaded teaching materials become the basis for a structured Course Blueprint, the blueprint becomes the source of truth for chat and activities, and the resulting student work flows back into review and teacher intelligence surfaces. That is the central product idea that differentiates the system from a thin AI wrapper or a one-off classroom demo.

2.2 Project goals

Based on the implemented system and supporting documentation, the project goals can be expressed as four connected product objectives rather than a flat checklist.

Structured knowledge creation. The first goal is to transform raw classroom materials into reusable, class-specific knowledge. The implemented platform does this through a materials library, asynchronous processing, and AI-assisted blueprint generation so that uploaded files become an organised teaching asset instead of a passive attachment store.

Teacher control and trust. The second goal is to keep instructors in control of what AI produces. The blueprint workflow is therefore not instant-publish generation: teachers edit the draft, approve it into an overview state, and publish it only when it is ready for students. The same idea extends to quiz and flashcard drafts, which are editable before assignment.

Guided student learning. The third goal is to give students a classroom workspace that feels specific to their class rather than generic to the internet. The implemented student experience centres on the published blueprint, always-on class chat, assignable quiz/flashcard/chat activities, and visible progress states such as assigned, in progress, submitted, and reviewed.

Operational credibility. The fourth goal is to demonstrate that the platform is credible as a real software product, not only as a concept. The current repository therefore includes a dedicated backend orchestration layer, queue-backed material processing, deployment documentation, automated tests across web and backend surfaces, and a sandboxed guest evaluation mode that allows realistic product walkthroughs without touching live classroom data.

2.3 What makes this project distinctive

What makes the project distinctive is not any single AI endpoint, but the way several design choices combine into a more complete classroom system.

Blueprint as the pedagogical control layer. The Course Blueprint is not decorative metadata. It is the product's central teaching object: it is generated from class materials,

edited by the teacher, versioned through draft/overview/published states, and then reused to ground downstream student experiences. This adds a meaningful editorial checkpoint that most GenAI classroom demos do not have.

A full classroom loop rather than isolated generation. The system supports an end-to-end workflow from teacher setup to student activity to teacher review. That means AI is used not just to generate content, but to support assignment creation, submission handling, feedback, chat monitoring, class insights, and teaching briefs. The product therefore models classroom operations, not only content synthesis.

A deliberate AI orchestration boundary. All AI generation routes through a dedicated Python FastAPI service rather than ad hoc provider calls from the web layer. This gives the system a clearer separation of concerns, consistent response contracts, and a stronger basis for provider routing, validation, and future extension.

Production-minded background and persistence design. Material processing is asynchronous and queue-backed, analytics and teaching briefs are snapshot oriented, and blueprint publication is treated as a state transition rather than a transient prompt result. These choices make the product feel much closer to a deployable platform than to a hackathon prototype.

An authentic guest evaluation path. Guest mode is implemented as a real sandbox classroom with anonymous authentication, seeded demo data, role switching, reset, expiry, and cleanup. That is a significantly stronger demonstration surface than a static landing page tour or a pre-recorded slideshow of product screens.

3 System Overview and Implemented Features

3.1 High-level system picture

Figure 1 shows the top-level structure of the current platform.

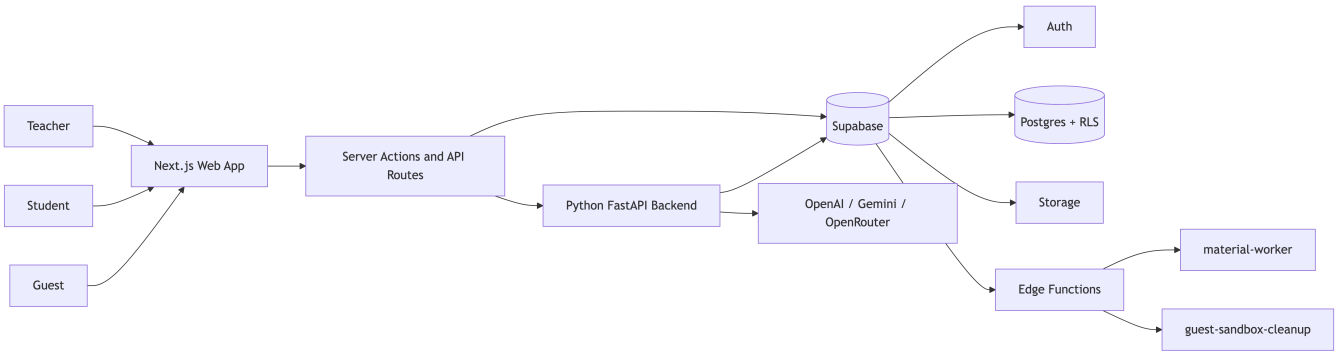

Figure 1: Current high-level platform architecture.

At a high level, teacher, student, and guest users all enter through the web application. The web layer handles UI rendering and user flow orchestration, while the backend is responsible

for AI-heavy logic and the Supabase layer provides persistence, storage, security, and async jobs.

3.2 Primary user groups

Table 1: Primary user groups in the current release

Role	Implemented responsibilities
Instructor	Create and manage classes, upload materials, curate and publish blueprints, generate and assign activities, review submissions, monitor chat behaviour, inspect insights, use the adaptive teaching brief, and preview the student journey from within the class workspace.
Student	Join classes with a join code, study the published blueprint, use always-on class chat, complete assigned chat/quiz/flashcard activities, and track current, upcoming, completed, and reviewed work from the student dashboard.
Guest	Enter a sandbox classroom through anonymous auth, explore seeded teacher and student workflows through role switching, reset the demo when needed, and evaluate the product without affecting real user data.

These user groups are not theoretical labels; they map directly to different product surfaces and navigation models in the implementation.

Instructor. The instructor experience is creation-first and decision-heavy. Teachers land in a dedicated dashboard, see their owned and assistant classes, and move into a class shell where they can upload materials, generate blueprints, create assignments, monitor student chats, and interpret class insights. The product also supports preview-as-student mode, which lets a teacher inspect the student-facing experience without leaving the classroom context.

Student. The student experience is intentionally simpler and more guided. Students enter through a separate dashboard, join classes through join codes, and then work inside a class workspace organised around the published blueprint, always-on chat, and assigned activities. Their dashboard and class pages emphasise due work, progress state, and reviewed feedback rather than creation or analytics tools.

Guest. The guest experience is designed for realistic evaluation rather than passive observation. Guests authenticate anonymously, receive a seeded sandbox classroom, and can switch between teacher and student perspectives, reset the environment, or convert to a real signup path. Middleware and sandbox state keep the guest confined to the sandbox classroom so the demo remains safe and operationally believable.

In addition to these primary personas, the implementation also supports a class-scoped **teaching assistant (TA)** authorization role. TA is not exposed as a separate permanent signup account type; instead, it exists as an enrollment-level role that can access the same teacher-oriented class workflows where route and service logic explicitly permit `teacher` or `ta`.

3.3 Feature set

Rather than presenting the system as a single AI chatbot, the current release delivers a set of user-facing classroom capabilities that work together as a guided teaching and learning platform. The most important design decision is that AI is always embedded inside a teacher-controlled class workflow: content is grounded in uploaded materials, reviewed through a blueprint, released through activities, and then interpreted through feedback and insights. The main implemented feature groups are summarised below.

Role-Based Access and Entry

The platform supports distinct entry paths for teachers and students rather than a single generic login followed by ad hoc navigation. Permanent users sign in with email and password, complete email verification, and then land in role-specific dashboards that match their responsibilities. Teachers enter management-oriented flows for classes, materials, blueprints, assignments, and insights; students enter a simpler workspace centred on class participation and assigned work.

This access model is implemented as a shared authentication surface rather than duplicated forms. The same auth component handles sign-in, sign-up, and password recovery in both the landing-page modal and dedicated auth pages, while server-side confirmation and recovery routing supports secure email verification and password reset completion. The result is a cleaner product experience for users and a more maintainable authentication boundary for the system.

Classroom Setup and Participation

For teachers, the first meaningful product workflow is class setup. A teacher can create a class, define its basic metadata, and immediately receive a join code that can be shared with students. Students can then join an existing class through a join-by-code flow and are placed directly into a class-scoped workspace with the right navigation, permissions, and learning surfaces for their role.

This capability is more than a simple CRUD screen. Class creation automatically enrolls the creating teacher, join codes are validated through a dedicated backend workflow, and join operations are designed to be safely repeatable rather than fragile one-time mutations. Once inside a class, the platform keeps users in a consistent class shell, and teachers can even preview the student experience in read-only mode without leaving the same classroom context.

Material Ingestion and Blueprint Publishing

The core differentiator of the platform is its material-to-blueprint workflow. Teachers can upload PDF, DOCX, and PPTX teaching materials into a class library, monitor their processing status, and manage them through preview, download, and delete actions. This turns the class workspace into a real content hub rather than a thin wrapper around a text prompt box.

Once materials are available, the platform uses them to generate a structured Course Blueprint that becomes the class source of truth. The generated blueprint is not exposed to students immediately: teachers edit the draft, adjust topics, objectives, and prerequisite

structure, approve it into an overview state, and then publish it when ready. This creates a clear editorial checkpoint and makes the AI output reviewable rather than automatic.

The implementation depth behind this feature is substantial. Material ingestion is asynchronous, with extraction, chunking, and embedding handled in the background so the system does not pretend that an uploaded file is instantly AI-ready. Blueprint generation produces structured payloads rather than free-form prose, while publication is owner-controlled and version-aware, allowing a teacher to create a new draft from the currently published blueprint without losing the stable student-facing version until the revised content is explicitly promoted.

AI Learning Activities for Students

After a blueprint is published, the platform turns that curated course knowledge into multiple learning experiences for students. Students can use an always-on class chat for open practice, and teachers can create formal chat, quiz, and flashcard assignments from the class blueprint. This gives the product a broader learning model than a one-dimensional question-answer interface.

Quiz and flashcard activities are generated as editable drafts, allowing teachers to refine the AI output before publishing it and assigning it to the whole class. Chat assignments add teacher-authored instructions to a guided conversation flow, while student dashboards and class views track assigned, in-progress, submitted, and reviewed states. Quiz flows support repeated attempts and score tracking, flashcard sessions capture known-versus-needs-review outcomes, and chat assignments preserve both the conversation transcript and student reflection for later review.

The student experience is also visually richer than plain text output. In both chat and data-rich contexts, the system can attach generative canvas responses such as charts and diagrams when a concept is better explained visually. This is especially valuable in STEM learning, where ideas such as processes, relationships, and trends are often easier to understand when rendered instead of only described.

Teacher Review and Instructional Intelligence

The platform does not stop at content generation or assignment delivery. Teachers can open dedicated review screens for chat, quiz, and flashcard assignments to inspect what students actually submitted, check completion status across the class, and record feedback. This shifts the product from “AI makes content” to “AI supports a full teaching cycle”.

The review experience is implemented with meaningful depth. Teachers can inspect quiz attempts and answers, read chat transcripts, review flashcard session outcomes, override or adjust scores where appropriate, and save comments plus highlights back to the student record. In parallel, a read-only chat monitor lets teachers inspect students’ always-on class chats for coaching and support without interfering with the student’s active workspace.

On top of review, the platform provides a teacher intelligence layer. The class intelligence dashboard aggregates quiz performance, topic outcomes, Bloom-level coverage, engagement patterns, student drill-downs, and intervention suggestions. A natural-language data-query panel lets a teacher ask questions about class performance and receive generated charts, while the adaptive teaching brief condenses the current class state into a memo-style summary with attention items, students to watch, likely misconceptions, strongest recommended action, and

suggested next steps. These features are backed by persisted snapshots so teacher-facing summaries remain stable across reloads and can be refreshed intentionally instead of regenerating unpredictably on every visit.

Guest Sandbox Evaluation Mode

Guest mode is one of the most distinctive parts of the release because it is implemented as a real interactive sandbox rather than a fake product tour. A visitor can enter from the landing page, authenticate anonymously, and receive a cloned classroom seeded with demo materials, blueprint data, activities, analytics, and chat history. This allows stakeholders to experience realistic teacher and student flows without touching live user data.

The sandbox experience includes role switching between teacher and student perspectives, reset capability for restarting the demo, and clean handoff into permanent signup when a guest wants to become a real user. It is also operationally disciplined: guest sessions are isolated through sandbox-scoped data, confined to allowed routes, limited by global session quotas, and expired after inactivity or maximum lifetime. A dedicated cleanup workflow then removes guest data, associated storage objects, and anonymous auth users so the feature remains sustainable in a hosted environment rather than becoming a one-off demo hack.

3.4 Blueprint-centered value flow

The most important end-to-end educational flow is shown in Figure 2.

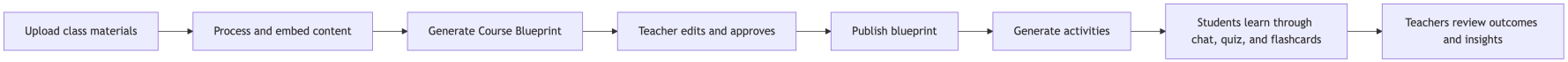

Figure 2: Blueprint-centered value flow from teacher materials to student learning and review.

This flow is central to the platform's pedagogy:

1. the instructor uploads materials;
2. the system processes and embeds those materials;
3. the AI generates a structured blueprint;
4. the instructor edits and approves the blueprint;
5. the published blueprint becomes the basis for activities;
6. students learn through grounded interactions;
7. instructors review outputs and analyze class performance.

4 System Design

4.1 Technology stack

Table 2: Core implementation stack

Layer	Technology
Frontend	Next.js 16 App Router, React 19, TypeScript, Tailwind CSS 4, shared UI primitives, Motion for React, Lucide icons
Backend	Python FastAPI, httpx, structured Pydantic schemas, provider adapters
Database and auth	Supabase PostgreSQL, Supabase Auth, Row Level Security
Storage and async processing	Supabase Storage, pgmq queue, pg_cron, Supabase Edge Functions
Testing	Vitest, React Testing Library, Python unittest, Playwright
Deployment model	Separate web and backend deployments plus hosted Supabase

4.2 Architectural decomposition

The current repository is intentionally partitioned into four main top-level areas:

- `web/`: user-facing routes, UI components, middleware, and server actions;
- `backend/`: AI orchestration, chat workspace logic, class workflows, analytics;
- `supabase/`: SQL migrations, local config, and Edge Functions;
- `tests/`: Playwright end-to-end coverage running against a deployed target URL.

This separation matters because different responsibilities are intentionally placed in the layer best suited for them. The web app owns rendering and navigation; the Python backend owns AI and workflow-heavy service logic; Supabase owns security, persistence, storage, and background jobs.

4.3 Web application design

The web application is not just a collection of pages. It implements a role-aware interface model with separate teacher and student dashboards, a persistent class shell, and route-level auth protection.

Important web-layer characteristics include:

- role-specific dashboards at `/teacher/dashboard` and `/student/dashboard`;
- a home-first auth model via a shared `AuthSurface` used in the landing-page modal and dedicated routes such as `/login`, `/register`, and `/forgot-password`;
- middleware-enforced redirects for unauthenticated, unverified, and expired guest sessions;
- server actions for class creation, join-by-code, materials, assignments, and settings;
- a shared design system with centralized icons, tokens, and motion presets.

On the teacher side, the class overview acts as a control hub for materials, assignments, teaching brief, and monitoring. On the student side, the class workspace is organized around focus widgets for AI chat, assignments, and the published blueprint. A teacher can also preview the student experience without changing accounts.

The auth surface is more substantial than a basic login form. The current implementation supports a landing-page modal flow triggered by `?auth=...`, fallback dedicated pages, server-side email confirmation and password-recovery callbacks through `/auth/confirm`, a dedicated `/reset-password` completion page, and URL-driven resend states for sign-up and forgot-password recovery. This improves consistency because the same auth component and redirect model are reused across both public entry points and email-link return flows.

4.4 Python backend design

The backend is the sole AI orchestration boundary in the current implementation. This is an important design choice because it avoids scattering prompt construction, provider credentials, and response normalization across the frontend.

The backend currently provides endpoints and domain logic for:

- blueprint generation;
- quiz generation;
- flashcard generation;
- grounded chat;
- chat workspace sessions and message persistence;
- visual canvas generation;
- class create and class join;
- materials dispatch;
- analytics, teaching brief, and natural-language data queries.

All normal backend responses follow a consistent envelope:

```
{ ok, data, error, meta }
```

This design improves consistency at the integration boundary. The frontend adapters can handle success and failure cases uniformly, while the backend retains freedom to evolve internal provider logic and prompt design.

4.5 AI orchestration design

The repository currently supports three pluggable providers: OpenRouter, OpenAI, and Gemini. Provider choice is environment-driven, and the backend can fall back across providers when needed.

This design has several advantages:

- the web app remains provider-agnostic;
- deployment environments can switch provider preference through configuration;
- provider failures can be isolated inside the backend;
- request deadlines are enforced centrally rather than inconsistently per route.

The current AI domains are broader than content generation alone. In addition to blueprint, quiz, and flashcard generation, the system also supports analytics narratives, teaching brief synthesis, chat memory handling, and visual canvas specifications.

4.6 Chat workspace and memory design

One of the most technically interesting parts of the system is the chat workspace. It is not implemented as a purely stateless prompt-response loop. Instead, the backend includes a dedicated chat workspace subsystem with participant listing, session creation and archive, paginated message history, and context compaction for long-running conversations.

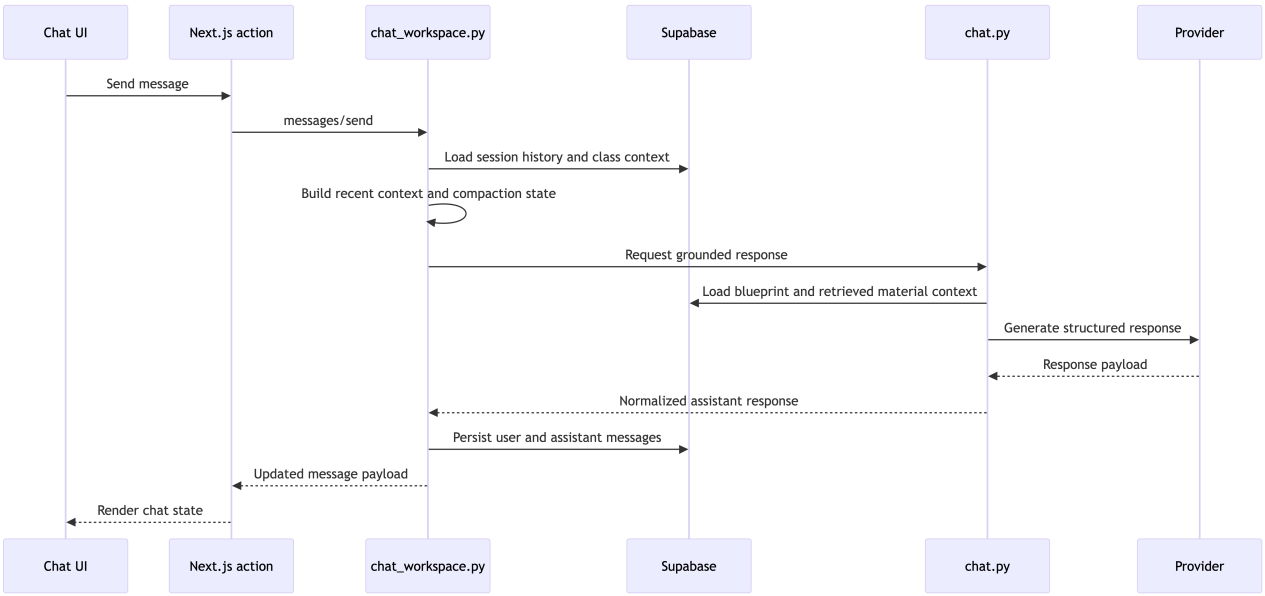

Figure 3: Chat workspace flow with grounded context retrieval and persisted assistant responses.

This design is significant for two reasons. First, it better reflects real classroom use, where students may return to a conversation over time rather than ask only one question. Second, it forces the system to deal with long-context management, not just one-shot prompt construction.

4.7 Material processing pipeline

Material ingestion is intentionally asynchronous. Uploading a file creates a material record and stores the file, but extraction, chunking, and embedding happen through a queue-backed worker path instead of blocking the user's request.

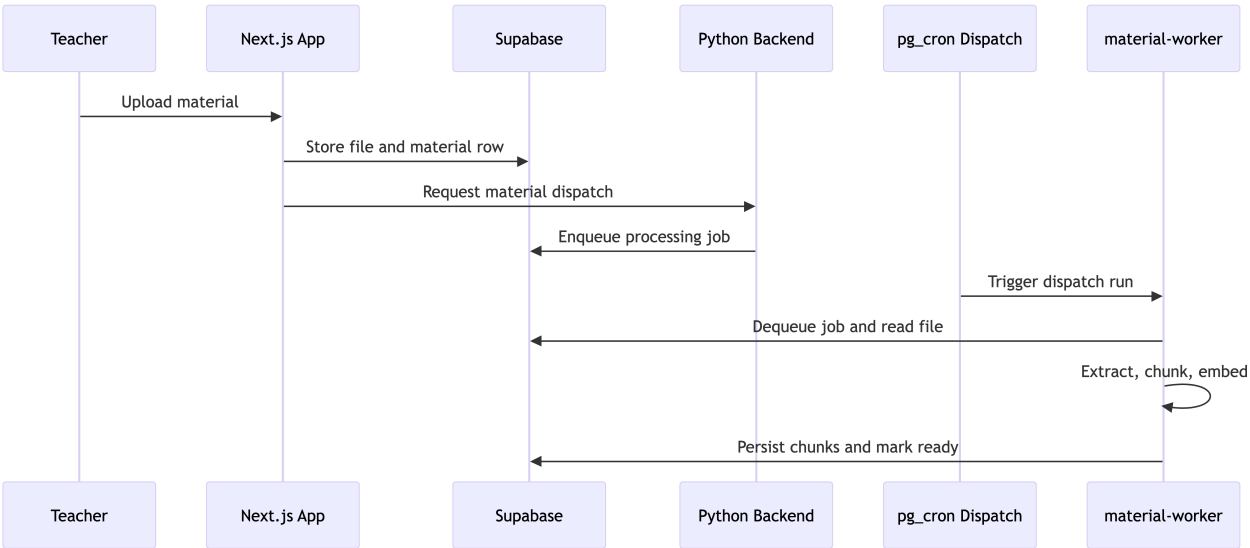

Figure 4: Asynchronous material-processing pipeline.

This was a good architectural decision for a course project because it addresses a real system

concern: extraction and embedding are too slow and failure-prone to treat as a trivial synchronous request. The queue-backed design allows better retry behavior, clearer UI states (`processing`, `ready`, `failed`), and a cleaner separation between user interaction and background work.

4.8 Analytics and adaptive teaching support

The platform includes teacher-facing intelligence features, which meaningfully extend it beyond content generation.

The class intelligence dashboard includes:

- summary cards for student count, average score, completion rate, and risk indicators;
- topic-level performance charts;
- Bloom-level breakdown visualization;
- student engagement views and student overview tables;
- AI-generated narrative interpretation and intervention suggestions;
- natural-language data query support for generating chart specifications.

The adaptive teaching brief is a complementary feature. Rather than exposing a large dashboard all the time, it provides a concise memo-style summary directly on the class overview page, with recommended next steps, likely misconceptions, and follow-up activity suggestions.

4.9 Security and access-control design

Security is handled across all three runtime surfaces:

- **web layer**: route protection, email verification enforcement, guest route confinement;
- **backend layer**: service authentication, user bearer-token verification, guest AI guardrails;
- **Supabase layer**: row-level security, teacher/enrollment policies, and sandbox-aware isolation.

The current implementation documents several security-conscious choices:

- permanent users are limited to teacher or student account types;
- `profiles.account_type` is immutable after signup;
- class-scoped teacher permissions can also be granted through the enrollment-level `ta` role without turning TA into a separate permanent account type;
- guest sessions are scoped by `sandbox_id`;
- cursor inputs to PostgREST are validated before interpolation;
- service-to-service auth between web and backend uses a shared backend API key.

4.10 Guest sandbox design

Guest mode is one of the strongest differentiators in the project. Instead of presenting a static marketing demo, the system provisions a real anonymous session and clones a seeded classroom into a sandboxed data space. Guests can switch between teacher and student views, reset the demo, and observe realistic product behavior without accessing real user data.

The current quota and lifecycle model combines Supabase-side and backend-side guardrails:

- a Supabase-managed `guest_session_quota` control table with RPCs that gate sandbox creation and quota release;
- current default caps of 60 active guest sandboxes globally and 20 newly created sandboxes per hour;
- backend limits on guest AI feature usage plus an `asyncio.Semaphore`-based concurrency gate for in-flight guest AI requests;
- expiry after 32 hours maximum or 8 hours of inactivity.

Cleanup is also part of the hardening story, not an afterthought. The `guest-sandbox-cleanup` path and related SQL cleanup functions release remaining quota counters, delete sandbox-scoped class data, and remove anonymous auth users so that demo sessions do not leak storage, quota state, or stale identities over time.

This is a thoughtful design because it balances demo accessibility with safety, resource control, and cleanup reliability.

5 Software Development Process

5.1 Requirements and scope shaping

The initial project brief encouraged teams to investigate stakeholder needs, review existing platforms, and avoid shallow AI-first implementations. The current repository reflects that direction. The system is not scoped as a universal learning platform, but as a structured STEM classroom assistant centered on teacher materials, editorial control, and student-facing learning activities.

A practical strength of the project is its restraint. The team did not attempt to implement every possible educational feature. Instead, it converged on a coherent workflow:

- content ingestion;
- blueprint generation and publishing;
- student chat and assignments;
- review and analytics;
- guest evaluation flow.

This focused scope likely helped the team build a more integrated product instead of a fragmented set of unrelated AI experiments.

5.2 Design process

The design process visible in the repository appears iterative and documentation-driven. The project contains:

- top-level design, architecture, UI/UX, and deployment documents;
- internal reference notes under `.codex/`;
- Mermaid diagrams exported to PNG for communication and reporting;
- commit history showing multiple phases of refinement rather than one-shot implementation.

The UI/UX work also appears to have been treated as a first-class concern. The repository contains significant evidence of design-token work, navigation restructuring, auth UX redesign, teacher/student flow differentiation, and consistency hardening. This is valuable because educational software quality depends not only on AI correctness, but also on clarity, trust, and ease of use.

5.3 Implementation phases observed in git history

The commit history provides a useful implementation timeline. Table 3 summarizes the major development phases visible from the repository.

Table 3: Major development phases observed from git history

Period	Main progression visible in the repository
2026-02-03 to 2026-02-05	Repository setup, initial schema and RLS, core class flows, materials pipeline, AI adapters, blueprint generation, and first UI scaffolding.
2026-02-06 to 2026-02-10	Vertical slices for AI chat, quiz generation, flashcards, auth hardening, and always-on class chat workspace.
2026-02-22 to 2026-03-02	Material worker stabilization, queue-backed processing, dashboard and class-shell UX improvements, theme/token refactoring, and stronger unit-test coverage.
2026-03-15 to 2026-03-24	Teacher class intelligence dashboard, generative canvas, teaching brief backend and widget, content review improvements, and more polished materials preview behavior.
2026-03-26 to 2026-03-28	Guest mode foundation and hardening, E2E expansion, shared auth redesign, email template work, OTP-based password change flow, and documentation refresh.
2026-04-04 to 2026-04-05	Guest quota redesign, concurrency improvements, final bug fixing, environment sync, and diagram/documentation alignment with runtime reality.

This sequence suggests a healthy development pattern:

1. build the skeleton;

2. deliver core vertical slices;
3. strengthen architecture and UX;
4. add analytics and guest mode;
5. harden the system and documentation near submission.

5.4 Collaboration workflow

The collaboration model combined a strong primary engineering lead with structured review, testing, documentation, and feedback support across the rest of Group #8. Haochen Fa served as the major developer and solution architect, leading the overall technical direction, system architecture, cross-service integration, deployment alignment, and most feature delivery. Other team members contributed through code review, feature and edge-case testing, product feedback, documentation work, and selected implementation tasks.

GitHub was the formal engineering workspace for the project. The team used GitHub Issues and pull requests to track implementation work, review changes, and communicate technical decisions, while WhatsApp was used for broader day-to-day discussion, rapid coordination, and design feedback. The main development repository is `HaochenFa/AI-Learning-Platform-for-STEM`, and the organization repository prepared for review and submission is `comp3122-2526sem2/groupproject-team_8`.

The current repository history is consistent with this operating model. It shows 403 commits, 92 merge commits, tagged release checkpoints, and repeated PR-based merges for guest mode, auth redesign, UI/UX improvements, analytics, documentation refreshes, and final hardening. This reflects a disciplined iterative workflow with clear integration checkpoints rather than a single large delivery at the end.

5.5 Use of GenAI during development

GenAI-assisted development was used deliberately as part of the delivery strategy for this project. Codex and Claude Code were used to accelerate scaffolding, refactoring, debugging, documentation maintenance, test-support work, and repetitive implementation tasks across the multi-service stack.

This workflow was effective because the AI tooling was guided by an experienced senior developer who could provide clear, verbose, and constraint-aware instructions, set the right architectural context, and quickly evaluate whether generated output matched the intended code logic, product behavior, and UI/UX direction. Prompt engineering was therefore not a superficial convenience; it was part of the engineering discipline that kept the generated work aligned with the system's actual requirements.

In practice, AI output was always paired with human validation. Generated or suggested changes were reviewed against feature behavior, code structure, testing needs, Git and GitHub workflow hygiene, dependency/tooling correctness, and the operational requirements of the web, backend, and Supabase layers. This made AI a force multiplier for rapid development without giving up ownership of correctness, maintainability, or product quality.

6 Testing, Quality Assurance, and Deployment

6.1 Testing strategy

The repository implements a layered testing strategy rather than relying on only one test type.

Table 4: Current testing layers in the repository

Layer	What it covers	Evidence in repo
Web unit and integration tests	Server actions, auth flows, route guards, material actions, blueprint logic, chat flows, guest helpers, UI primitives, validation helpers	61 test files under `web/src`
Backend unit tests	Providers, schemas, class flows, blueprint generation, quiz, flashcards, materials, analytics, chat workspace, guest rate limiting	20 Python test files under `backend/tests`
End-to-end tests	Teacher navigation, student navigation, login, join class, settings, sign-out, and guest entry against a deployed environment	10 Playwright specs under `tests/e2e`

Representative quality signals include:

- guest middleware tests and guest sandbox tests;
- blueprint action tests;
- materials extraction and retrieval tests;
- chat generation, compaction, and workspace tests;
- analytics and teaching brief action tests;
- Playwright flows for both teacher and student navigation.

6.2 Why the testing approach is appropriate

This testing distribution is appropriate for the architecture:

- unit tests catch domain logic regressions close to the code;
- web integration tests validate server actions and route behavior;
- backend tests verify AI-related orchestration and guardrails without needing full browser runs;
- Playwright tests confirm that the deployed user flows still work end to end.

For a project involving multiple services and stateful workflows, this layered approach is far more credible than relying on only manual demonstration.

6.3 Deployment topology

The deployed system consists of a frontend deployment, a separate backend deployment, and a hosted Supabase project. Figure 5 captures this structure.

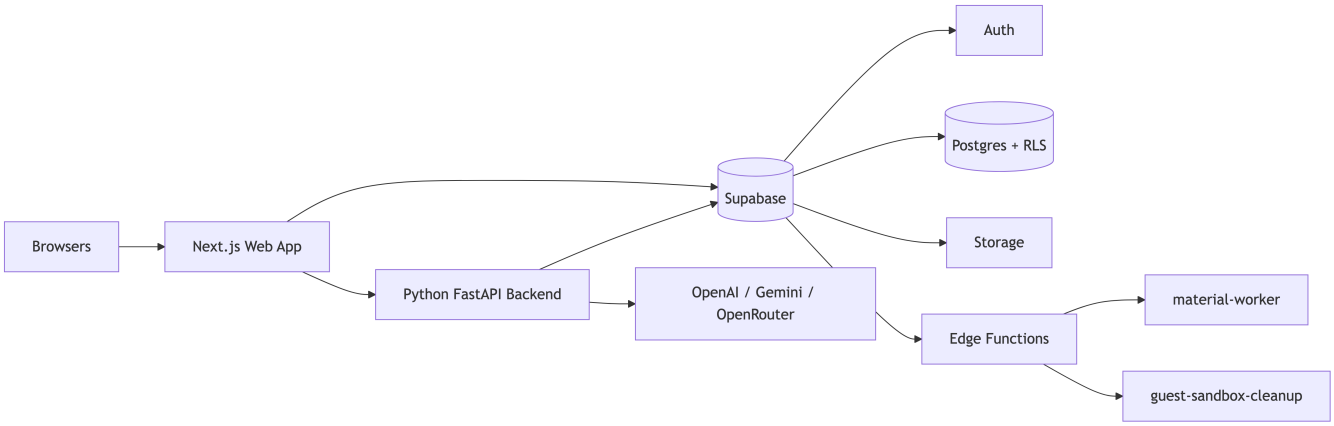

Figure 5: Hosted deployment topology across frontend, backend, and Supabase services.

This split has practical benefits:

- frontend issues can be distinguished from backend issues;
- AI orchestration can evolve independently from the UI deployment;
- Supabase-specific operational tasks such as migrations and Edge Function secrets remain explicit;
- the team can test preview or staging environments in a more controlled way.

6.4 Deployment process

The documented deployment workflow includes:

1. configuring one Supabase project per environment;
2. applying the active migration set;
3. deploying the `material-worker` and `guest-sandbox-cleanup` Edge Functions;
4. configuring Edge Function secrets and Vault-backed values;
5. deploying the Python backend;
6. deploying the web application;
7. running post-deploy smoke tests for auth, teacher flows, student flows, insights, and guest mode.

Operationally, this is a mature approach for a course project because it recognizes that deployment is not just "push frontend to Vercel"; the data plane and async workers also have to be correct. For guest mode specifically, deployment also has to keep the Supabase quota RPCs, backend guest-limit environment variables, and cleanup worker aligned so that session caps, inactivity expiry, and concurrency guardrails behave consistently across the whole stack.

6.5 Database evolution

The current migration history shows 23 active migrations, which is another sign that the project evolved iteratively rather than remaining static after an initial schema dump.

Major migration themes include:

- initial schema and RLS foundation;
- quiz integrity and auth hardening;
- canonical blueprint snapshots;
- always-on class chat and compaction;
- queue-backed material processing;
- class insights and teaching brief snapshots;
- guest mode schema, seed data, cleanup, and quota redesign.

This migration history is important because it mirrors the product's evolution in a traceable, reviewable form.

7 Lessons Learned and Reflection

7.1 Technical lessons

The repository's maintained documentation highlights several concrete lessons that are worth reflecting on.

- **A clean architecture boundary matters.** Routing all AI through the Python backend keeps provider-specific complexity out of the UI and gives the system a stable application-facing contract.
- **Async processing is necessary for realistic content pipelines.** Material extraction and embedding do not belong in a naive synchronous upload request if the goal is a reliable system.
- **Guest mode is harder than it looks.** A believable demo mode requires session quotas, expiry, cleanup, sandbox isolation, and backend-side ownership checks. A demo that looks simple in the UI can still be architecturally complex.
- **Deployment secrets must live in the right place.** The project explicitly notes that Supabase Edge Functions cannot rely on Vercel secrets or Supabase Vault alone; function-level secrets must be configured in Supabase Edge Function Secrets.
- **Subtle browser and CSS issues can become product bugs.** Examples in the repository include iframe preview limitations caused by storage response headers and dialog-centering issues caused by Tailwind v4's use of the standalone CSS `translate` property.

7.2 Process lessons

From a software engineering process perspective, several lessons stand out:

- keeping design, architecture, deployment, and UI docs current reduces confusion late in the project;
- documentation is especially valuable when a project spans frontend, backend, and database layers;
- a branch-and-merge workflow helps isolate major features such as guest mode and auth redesign;
- testing should expand together with complexity, not after the system is already unstable.

7.3 What the project did well

In its current form, the project demonstrates several strengths:

- a coherent product concept instead of a scattered list of AI features;
- strong teacher-centered workflow design;
- real effort on UI quality and navigation clarity;
- a credible multi-service architecture;
- meaningful testing and deployment documentation.

7.4 Next-stage expansion opportunities

As a platform with a strong core already in place, the project also has clear next-stage expansion paths:

- richer operator tooling around observability, release health, and administrative reporting;
- broader activity formats beyond the current chat, quiz, and flashcards set;
- deeper analytics and intervention workflows for longitudinal classroom support;
- further packaging of deployment and runbook automation for smoother environment provisioning.

8 User and Operations Manual

8.1 Administrator Manual (Deployment and Operations)

The administrator role in this platform is centered on environment setup, Supabase project administration, release deployment, and operational data management. In practice, administrators use the deployment pipeline, Supabase Dashboard, SQL editor, environment configuration, and health checks to operate the system across the web app, Python backend, Edge Functions, and hosted Supabase project.

A. Initial platform setup

1. Create and configure the target Supabase project.
2. Enable email/password auth and email confirmation.
3. Enable Anonymous Auth if guest mode is required.
4. Set the Site URL and redirect URLs for local and hosted environments.
5. Apply the active database migrations in `supabase/migrations`.
6. Deploy the two required Edge Functions:
   - `material-worker`
   - `guest-sandbox-cleanup`
7. Configure required secrets for the backend and both Edge Functions.
8. Deploy the web app and Python backend.
9. Verify the live environment and smoke-test the deployed product.

B. Core operational responsibilities

- Maintain environment variables for the web app, backend, and Edge Functions.
- Apply the branded confirmation and recovery email templates in Supabase.
- Ensure `PYTHON_BACKEND_URL` and backend API-key alignment across services.
- Monitor guest-mode capacity and cleanup health.
- Run post-deploy smoke tests after releases.
- Investigate common failure modes such as:
  - guest entry failures;
  - materials stuck in `processing`;
  - auth links redirecting to the wrong domain;
  - web UI loading while AI features fail due to backend or provider issues.

C. Common operating commands

Local development and verification

```
pnpm install
pip install -r backend/requirements.txt
pnpm dev
uvicorn app.main:app --app-dir backend --host 0.0.0.0 \
  --port 8001 --reload
pnpm test
python3 -m unittest discover -s backend/tests -p 'test_*.py'
```

Supabase deployment and schema operations

```
npx supabase db push
npx supabase functions deploy material-worker
npx supabase functions deploy guest-sandbox-cleanup
```

Frontend deployment

```
cd web
npx --yes vercel --yes --prod
```

Backend health verification

```
curl https://<backend-domain>/healthz
```

D. Useful Supabase Dashboard and SQL operations

The Supabase Dashboard is the main administrative control surface for account support, data inspection, and operational maintenance. Authentication issues can be handled in **Authentication -> Users**, storage artifacts can be reviewed in **Storage**, and targeted data operations can be executed through the **SQL Editor**. The following queries are directly aligned with the current schema.

Inspect user accounts, confirmation state, and profile roles

```
select
  u.id,
  u.email,
  u.email_confirmed_at,
  p.display_name,
  p.account_type
from auth.users u
left join public.profiles p on p.id = u.id
order by u.created_at desc;
```

Register a platform administrator

```
insert into public.admin_users (user_id)
values ('<user-uuid>'::uuid)
on conflict (user_id) do nothing;
```

Update a user's display name

```
update public.profiles
set display_name = '<new-display-name>'
where id = '<user-uuid>'::uuid;
```

Review classes and join codes

```
select id, title, subject, level, join_code, archived, created_at
from public.classes
order by created_at desc;
```

Inspect material-processing state and latest job status

```
select
  m.id,
  c.title as class_title,
  m.title as material_title,
  m.status,
  j.stage,
  j.attempts,
  j.last_error,
  m.created_at
from public.materials m
join public.classes c on c.id = m.class_id
left join public.material_processing_jobs j on j.material_id = m.id
order by m.created_at desc;
```

Review guest sandboxes and manually mark a sandbox for cleanup

```
select id, user_id, class_id,
       status, guest_role, expires_at, last_seen_at
from public.guest_sandboxes
order by created_at desc;

update public.guest_sandboxes
set status = 'expired', expires_at = now()
where id = '<sandbox-uuid>'::uuid;
```

Run a manual cleanup pass from the SQL editor when required

```
select public.cleanup_expired_guest_sandboxes(50);
```

8.2 Instructor Manual

A. Create an account and sign in

Public auth can start either from the landing-page modal flow or from the dedicated fallback routes `/login`, `/register`, and `/forgot-password`. Confirmation and password-recovery emails return through the same server-side callback route before the user is redirected back into the appropriate auth surface.

1. Open the deployed application.
2. Choose **Create an account**.
3. Select the **teacher** account type.

4. Enter email and password.
5. Verify the email using the confirmation link.
6. Sign in and open the **Teacher Dashboard**.

B. Create and manage a class

1. From the Teacher Dashboard, click **Create class**.
2. Fill in class title and optional metadata such as subject and level.
3. Submit the form.
4. The system creates the class and generates a join code.
5. Share the join code with students so they can enroll from the student side.

C. Upload teaching materials

1. Open the target class.
2. Use the materials upload form to upload PDF, DOCX, or PPTX files.
3. Wait for the system to process the material.
4. Monitor status as `processing`, `ready`, or `failed`.
5. When the material is ready, use the actions menu to preview, download, or delete it.

D. Generate and publish the Course Blueprint

1. Open the class blueprint page.
2. Trigger blueprint generation after materials are ready.
3. Review the generated summary, topics, and objectives.
4. Edit the blueprint draft where needed.
5. Approve the draft and move it into overview.
6. Publish the blueprint when it is ready for student use.

E. Create learning activities

The current release supports three main activity types:

- chat assignments;
- quizzes;
- flashcards.

To create an activity:

1. Ensure a published blueprint exists.
2. Open the relevant activity creation route from the class page.
3. Generate or configure the activity.
4. Review and edit the content where applicable.
5. Publish or assign it to the class.

F. Review submissions

1. Open an assignment's review page.
2. View student recipients, completion states, and submitted content.
3. For chat assignments, inspect transcript and reflection content.
4. For quiz assignments, inspect scores and answers.
5. For flashcards, inspect review statistics and score summaries.
6. Save teacher feedback for the selected submission.

G. Monitor class progress and teaching support

1. Open the class overview to see the adaptive teaching brief.
2. Refresh the brief when more activity data becomes available.
3. Open **Insights** for the class intelligence dashboard.
4. Review charts, student summaries, AI narrative, and intervention suggestions.
5. Use the natural-language data query panel for custom chart-oriented questions.

H. Preview the student experience

1. Open the class page as a teacher.
2. Activate student preview mode using the student-view route state.
3. Inspect how published blueprint, AI chat, and assignment widgets appear to students.
4. Exit preview mode to return to the teacher control surface.

8.3 Student Manual

A. Create an account and sign in

Students use the same shared auth surface as teachers. They can start from the landing-page modal or from the dedicated auth pages, and email confirmation/recovery links are completed through the same server-side callback path before the final redirect back into the app.

1. Open the deployed application.

2. Choose **Create an account**.
3. Select the **student** account type.
4. Enter email and password.
5. Verify the email using the confirmation link.
6. Sign in and open the **Student Dashboard**.

B. Join a class

1. From the Student Dashboard or sidebar, open **Join class**.
2. Enter the join code provided by the instructor.
3. Submit the form.
4. After joining successfully, open the class workspace.

C. Use the student dashboard

The student dashboard organizes assignments into categories such as:

- due now;
- upcoming;
- completed.

Students can use the dashboard to quickly identify overdue or active work and jump directly into the relevant class or assignment.

D. Navigate the class workspace

Within a class, students can access:

- AI chat;
- chat assignments;
- quizzes;
- flashcards;
- the published blueprint.

The workspace is intentionally more focused and less administratively dense than the teacher view.

E. Use AI chat

1. Open the class page and select the AI chat widget or direct chat view.
2. Ask questions related to the class materials and published blueprint.
3. Review the grounded AI response.
4. Continue the conversation as needed.

AI chat becomes available once the instructor publishes the blueprint, ensuring that responses are grounded in approved class content.

F. Complete assignments

1. Open the assigned activity from the dashboard or class workspace.
2. For chat assignments, complete the conversation and submit the required reflection.
3. For quizzes, answer the questions and submit the attempt.
4. For flashcards, complete the review session and submit progress.
5. Revisit the assignment later to see updated status such as submitted or reviewed.

G. Use the published blueprint

1. Open the blueprint widget or blueprint page inside the class.
2. Review topics and learning objectives.
3. Use the blueprint as a study guide before attempting quizzes or asking AI chat questions.

H. Manage account settings

1. Open **Settings**.
2. Update display name if needed.
3. Use the two-step password change flow with verification code if required.
4. Open **Help** for role-specific FAQ and suggested next steps.

8.4 Supplementary Guest Demo Flow

In addition to the required admin, instructor, and student manuals, the guest workflow is worth documenting because it is a significant implemented feature.

1. From the landing page, choose **Continue as guest** when guest mode is enabled.
2. The system provisions an anonymous authenticated session and clones sandbox data.
3. Explore the classroom in teacher view or switch to student view.
4. Reset the sandbox if a fresh walkthrough is needed.
5. Create a permanent account from a clean state if you want to move into normal usage.

9 Conclusion

The current repository demonstrates a serious course project with a clear educational purpose, a layered architecture, meaningful GenAI integration, and a credible software engineering process. Its strongest design choice is the decision to center the product on a teacher-curated Course Blueprint rather than on generic AI chat alone. That decision gives the entire system coherence: materials, activities, student chat, review, and analytics all connect back to the same core object.

Equally important, the project goes beyond feature implementation and addresses the concerns that often separate prototypes from robust systems: asynchronous processing, security boundaries, role-aware access control, test coverage, deployment topology, and realistic demo-mode isolation. For a final project, this makes the platform not only functional, but also defensible from a software engineering perspective.

A Repository Evidence Used for This Report

This report was prepared against the current repository state using the following main sources:

- top-level documents:
  - `README.md`
  - `ARCHITECTURE.md`
  - `DESIGN.md`
  - `UIUX.md`
  - `DEPLOYMENT.md`
  - `AGENTS.md`
  - `CLAUDE.md`
- subsystem documentation:
  - `web/README.md`
  - `backend/README.md`
  - `supabase/README.md`
- course materials:
  - `project_overivew.pdf`
  - `project_background.pdf`
- implementation evidence:
  - key web routes and server actions
  - backend service modules
  - Supabase Edge Functions
  - migration history
  - git commit history and merge history
  - test suites and E2E specs

B Submission and Live System Links

- Live product: ai-stem-learning-platform-group-8.vercel.app
- Primary development repository: HaochenFa/AI-Learning-Platform-for-STEM
- Organization submission repository: comp3122-2526sem2/groupproject-team_8